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Joe LaBarbera

Joe LaBarbera has been a drummer of choice for Woody Herman, Chuck Mangione, Bill Evans, and numerous other jazz luminaries. He recently retired from CalArts following a successful teaching career. Joe's brothers, Pat and John, are also noted musicians in the field of jazz.

Joe was interviewed via Zoom on July 15, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College. I'm very pleased to have Joe LaBarbera with me. I'll introduce you as a drummer, composer, jazz educator, and author.

JL: Soon-to-be, Monk.

MR: Soon-to-be. Well we're going to talk about that. I see it looks like you've survived the Covid time intact. How did you keep busy?

JL: Well it was actually my final semester at CalArts. I retired just at the end of the spring semester, at the end of June, after 28 years. So I was doing that here, and I have a handful of private students as well and then my wife was busy with her job in the office, you know, one room down. So I had to negotiate when I could crash and bang and you know when she needed silence for important meetings. But it worked out, I mean honestly, for us, we thrived. We were together every day all day, three meals a day. We haven't had that in 26 years of marriage.

MR: Yeah. Funny how things work out. I want to offer up a quote from an earlier interview you did. It said, and you said, "From the age of twelve on my course was set. I knew it was something that I wanted to do and I was not going to be talked out of it. I think you have to have that attitude if you're going to survive in this business" meaning the music business. Do you try to pass that on to your students or people that think that this is a glamorous life and boy I sure want to do that?

JL: Absolutely. I mean that's part of being a mentor, when you have a student and you are designated as your mentor, as we are at CalArts. It's important that you're telling them the truth about what — about the realities of being a jazz musician. So you have to be willing to accept just maybe the — just the reward that the music brings you and then hopefully if you're working at it hard enough then financial benefits will flow from that. Right? If you're getting into this, and I've had students that were focused mainly on celebrity more than the music itself, that's the wrong, that really is the wrong motivation.

MR: Your motivation when you were nine or ten was jumpstarted by your father and your brothers. Did your father try to instill some of that reality in you or was it sort of like just a way for the family to be together?

JL: I think it was more of that, Monk, because we as a family did everything together. We were all in music together, we were all in scouting together, and because of that involvement, Pat and John and I are all Eagle Scouts, because my parents were involved in everything that we do, right? So I believe it was more about the family community, the family commitment, and also at that age someone might say I want to be the president or a fireman or whatever, you know, and of course you're allowed to say that. But as it got closer to the reality of going into the music as a profession, I think that's when our parents started to become a little more concerned but they never ever tried to deter us. They never said anything about, you know, don't do this. They just said it's going to be difficult. And Pop for sure knew about the realities of the music business as a profession.

MR: Had he tried it?

JL: He tried it to the extent that you could in the community we're from which is 4,500 people, still. He wasn't going to make a living from it, but it was always his avocation and he always led bands and he knew what musicians were going through that were trying to carve out an existence just playing music. Impossible in that area you know.

MR: So when you were ten, or in that age — if your friends said, "Come on, Joe, we've got a team together, we're going to play baseball." And you said, "Oh man, I've got a gig." Did you actually say "gig" at the time or what did you say?

JL: No, we called them jobs. It was a dance job you know. And at ten years old I might have been more inclined to go with the guys to play you know, but by the time I was twelve then the music had really captivated all three of us. We were just completely in love with jazz. So that was our total focus from that point forward.

MR: When he — he had stock arrangements for a lot of the things that you did. Were there drum parts and were you expected to follow them?

JL: No. I mean there were drum parts, Monk, but if you look at any of those stocks from the 30s, the drum part really, what's designated for playing time is basically four quarter notes connected by rolls, and four beats on the bass drum. You know that's kind of a ballpark approximation of what, you know, Baby Dodds would have played or any of the early drummers, you know, that kind of real — nothing on the ride cymbal. There was no ride cymbal. It was all about playing the time on the snare drum. So I started out playing in that style of Baby Dodds.

MR: What if someone wanted to do a rumba? Would your father have vocalized the beat to you?

JL: Yes. He would have sung it to me, play it like this, and then I would do my best to imitate it.

MR: Okay. And the drums wasn't the only part of your musical education, am I correct? Like you played a clarinet and sax a bit?

JL: That's correct. I started drums at five, and then by the time I was seven I think or eight, my embouchure had fully formed so I took up the clarinet and then that was followed by the saxophone. And I played that all through high school.

MR: I see. I think that must have paid some dividends down the road when you decided that you wanted to compose also, would that be —

JL: That's true, Monk, sorry I didn't mean to interrupt you. It also paid the most dividend when I was starting to improvise with other musicians and I had that melodic sense kind of ingrained into my head about what music is supposed to sound like. You know I could almost visualize the perspective of the saxophone player as that person would relate to the drummer. You know?

MR: Um hum. I've picked up, our viewers should know that I have also met with your two brothers so a few little anecdotes: I understand that the band and Steve Gadd auditioned for the Mickey Mouse Club.

JL: That's right.

MR: And he beat you all, is that correct?

JL: He did. That is correct. Hey listen, if you're going to lose to somebody it might as well be somebody great you know.

MR: Is it true that you had to start taking tap dance lessons after that? Because Steve tap danced?

JL: That is true. Yep.

MR: But then you replaced him in 1968 with Gap Mangione?

JL: Yes. I took his place when he enlisted in the army, I took that gig, which only lasted a matter of months because I was drafted very quickly. This was 1968, right? But I got through my military service fortunately and came home and went back with Gap and then went out with Woody's band.

MR: I was curious about that if you got drafted or if you had enlisted. And gee at that time, how were you able to get out in two years?

JL: With a lot of lobbying. I mean fortunately, this is kind of an interesting story. You arrive at the induction center in the dark of night, so you don't know where you are, you're completely disoriented, they stick you in a barracks. But as luck would have it the band that I would eventually be stationed in was in the induction center. So I hear guys playing to I immediately like snuck out of the barracks, went over and started jamming with these guys, and put myself on their radar from day one. So all the way through basic training I

was going over there, playing with these guys, you know, ingratiating myself as much as I could, and by the time we were given our orders after basic training, mine was to go to the 173rd Army Band in the induction center and that's where I stayed for the next two years.

MR: Well I can add that to quite a few stories we've heard from musicians who made their way through the military and sometimes escaped combat because that they were able to play and be versatile.

JL: You know I go back to my father about this, because he taught generations of young boys in my hometown starting with the 30s, and I cannot tell you how many of these grown-ups would come to us later when we would meet them and they would say, "Your father saved my life during World War II because I was able to get into a band" here or there or wherever. So I was extremely fortunate, Monk.

MR: Did your parents live long enough to witness the success of all three of you in the music business?

JL: Absolutely. My father used to take great pride in telling Woody Herman that he was the real Joe LaBarbera. Or the original Joe LaBarbera. Yeah, Pop, my parents met Woody, they met Buddy, I don't know, they never met Bill, because we were in New York and my parents weren't traveling to New York at the time mostly. I'm pretty sure they met Elvin, Pat would have spoken to that though. But yeah they met all the bands. Everybody knew them. I mean I'm sure Pat or John must have said that after one of the gigs in Rochester the entire Buddy Rich band bus pulled up in front of our parents' home at three o'clock in the morning and my mother got out of bed and started cooking and my father brings out the wine, the home-made wine, and they partied until dawn and then they all climbed on the bus and off they went.

MR: My family passed through Mount Morris numerous times on the way to Angelica, New York.

JL: Oh I know where that is, sure.

MR: Where they grew up. So we were in Rochester so I never knew that I was traveling through a town that had a famous band. Did the idea of pursuing a music career necessarily include college?

JL: I think the college aspect of it was simply the road that everyone was taking. You know all of my classmates were going on to college. Pat and John had previously enrolled in State University of New York at Potsdam, and they both — Pat transferred out of there and went to Berklee College in Boston. So yes, I think it was simply that I was following my brothers once again, whatever path they would take I was going to take it. And I'm pretty sure I knew at least enough to know that I didn't know much and I needed more.

MR: That's a good thing to know.

JL: Yeah.

MR: The idea of going to school and sort of jockeying in position with the other drummers, and where did you fall in that hierarchy?

JL: Pretty good actually, right away. I mean Harvey Mason and I, he was a year ahead of me but we were the two guys basically from our generation. The real guy was Peter Donald, who was three years our senior at that point. So he was getting ready to graduate when I got to Berklee but I was known right away because I could play a little bit. You know I could play pretty good time and I knew tunes. So that's really all it was about and then I wanted to play all the time as did everyone else, so —

MR: Did the music of the pop world have much influence on your listening habits or did you feel desire to get into, well I'll call it rock music?

JL: No. Not at all.

MR: Really?

JL: It just, you know we heard Bill Evans and Miles and Coltrane when we were in our early teens. I mean that just captivated us. How could we compare that with what was being played on the radio at that time? We're talking 1960 now. There really is no comparison. I have grown to love the pop music from that era now. I listen to it now. I'm playing catch-up with that and really enjoying it. At the time, Monk, I had no use for it whatsoever.

MR: When you were listening to Bill Evans and Cannonball and all that, did you sense the song form and what the band was doing to make a seven minute performance into a cohesive listenable piece of music?

JL: Not that early on. All I know is that we were completely engaged from the second that needle hit the grooves of the LP until the side was over, it was just like that music completely captivated us and drew us in and didn't release us until it was finished.

MR: Okay I'm getting a picture in my head of the three of you in one of your bedrooms with that LP going and like, "Oh, listen to that, listen to that, oh."

JL: Close. It was in the basement or it was in the kitchen. It was a portable job you know, real small, one and a half watts of power, and we would take that everywhere. So we would be listening in the basement constantly and then we'd take it upstairs and play it during dinner and our parents were just fine you know. My father started singing along with Gerry Mulligan after a while.

MR: I guess he was the first Joe LaBarbera.

JL: He was.

MR: So Woody Herman was, who was on the band at that time that showed you the ropes, that sort of jazz education that you can't get in school?

JL: Yeah — let's see Alan Broadbent, who had been a classmate, although we didn't really engage that much at Berklee, but he was there when I was there. He was on the band. He helped me. Sal Nistico was still on the band and Sal was someone that we really admired coming from Western, New York — he was from Syracuse. He was there. Frank Tiberi, who was with the band probably the longest of anybody, he was still there in the sax section and he always had advice for every drummer. So yeah, he was — all those guys would share their knowledge. That band in particular had more older musicians on it you know. It was probably 50-50 experienced players and guys just out of college or just out of the army or you know, just getting started.

MR: What might you have done that Woody Herman would not like, as a drummer?

JL: Well if you weren't listening, if you weren't paying attention, if you weren't swinging the band, you were out of there. I mean Woody was notorious. He would walk right over to where you're sitting and point to Bill Byrne who was the band manager right behind you and say, "Get me another drummer for tomorrow night." I mean he could be that cold. If it wasn't happening he wasn't going to waste any time you know.

MR: It's interesting you say that about concentration because that's not necessarily a given with musicians. You're playing along and you're thinking about man I've got to get to a laundromat or I haven't sent my rent check home, and that's not a good thing.

JL: You know that's something that Bill Evans addressed pretty thoroughly in that creative process video he did years ago with his brother Harry. And it's something that I discuss also in the book. It's about Bill used to say I flip a switch and then all of my concentration is focused on whatever I'm doing right then and there, and nothing gets in the way. I know exactly what you're talking about, thinking ahead about, you know, what am I going to have for dinner, did I take out the trash, I mean blah-blah-blah. If you allow it, you could be bombarded with external input of things that don't relate to the music or the task at hand. So that's something that musicians, you really have to train yourself for that.

MR: Was there music, this is sort of a similar question about when you were in the family band, was there drum music for most of Woody's charts?

JL: There absolutely was but like most of my predecessors from that era, and even drummers that followed me, we learned Woody's book from listening to Jake Hanna play it, you know, on all of those "Woody '63" and there's like three albums I think that they did around that time where Jake just kills it. And we listened to them so many times that, I know Jeff Hamilton says the same thing, we knew that book cold before we even walked into the gig.

MR: How did you adapt to living on a bus?

JL: I loved it. You know 21 years old, I'm out with a band that I've loved since I was a kid, I've got heroes on that band: Frank Vicari who I knew from Maynard's band, and Bobby Burgess and Al Porcino and Sal Nistico. And Woody, you know? So I loved — I didn't mind it at all at first.

MR: At first.

JL: Yeah well Monk, think about it. You're on a bus with 16 other guys day in day out, night after night. You know you start to rub on each other a little bit.

MR: Sure. And I've looked at itineraries for bands and it's fascinating how one night you could be playing like a dance at a VFW, the next night you're playing a jazz festival with, you know, like the ups and downs of the life are very fascinating.

JL: It points to the economics of running a big band. I remember, I always tell my jazz history students Duke Ellington received the presidential, president's medal of freedom from Richard Nixon and then the next night he was playing a high school prom in a local DC area high school gymnasium. That tells the whole story right there.

MR: If my math is correct there was only about seven years between Woody Herman and Bill Evans. Is that correct?

JL: Yeah. That's about right.

MR: Do you think you could have handled the gig with Bill Evans if you were 21, like when you joined Woody Herman?

JL: I don't think so, but I don't know. I don't know the answer to that. Honestly there are days when I think that I might just now be qualified to take that gig with Bill, honestly man. I mean you go through all of this, all of these periods of growth and self-examination and self-editing and all of, a lot of other things. But fortunately it came at a time I think when I'd had enough experience under my belt to be able to walk in there feeling confident that I could do the job.

MR: Can you expand on "self-editing"?

JL: What we play as musicians, you know, we're the most self-critical people there are. We're listening to ourselves play and if you're doing a recording and you're hearing the recording played back you say to yourself, "Oh man I've played that idea so many times, I've got to get that out of my vocabulary. That's done for now." Things like that, you know? Or if you find an obvious flaw in what you're doing. You're constantly examining yourself.

MR: Were the people you played, the leaders, would they tell you, would they give you guidance, would they like chew you out or was it sort of like, apparently Count Basie wouldn't say anything unless he was really unhappy. So I'm just wondering, did you ever be — like look for guidance or almost welcome it and not get it?

JL: I don't know that I ever actually asked anybody, but I was fortunate in that Woody's band, Chuck's band — Chuck Mangione's band, Bill Evans, and all the different sidemen— all the different leaders that I worked for in New York, they really hired you for you, so they allowed you to learn or they allowed your input. They wanted you to interpret the music the way you heard it.

MR: I love the music of Chuck Mangione and I actually — full disclosure, I asked Gap, I said, "Well what are some things I should know about Joe?" And he said nice things, rest assured. He sent me a link to a really nice video of the group when you were in it, 1980 Live at Monterey, and there's a full tune on there, it's fairly lengthy. And you have an extended drum solo on it, and I noticed that you started just on the snare drum and you started this pretty like intricate rhythm, and then you picked it up and you moved it around. And earlier when you were talking about listening to horn players compositionally, it sort of connects with that drum solo. So is there a question here? My question is when you have a drum solo, are you trying to think compositionally?

JL: Absolutely. In fact when I'm accompanying I try to think compositionally. I look at the big picture in music, always. So from the minute that tune is counted off I'm tracking the growth, the dynamic ups and downs, how much I'm adding, if I can maybe dial it back. I'm watching all of that. I'm trying to observe the music. I know that's something, a cliché almost that people say all the time but it's such a good way to think about it. You know if you're really focused on the music and not your part so much, then I think you're going to get a better result and I can say emphatically that Bill Evans was that way, even though he was a giant and a major star, the music was always the most important thing. He never put himself above what we were doing musically.

MR: Yeah I believe you said he had no ego when he was playing. Is that correct?

JL: That is correct.

MR: Yeah well he had nice things to say about you, that you were willing to pay, you were willing to make the concessions of dues toward the end of playing quality music.

JL: Yeah. That meant a lot to him. With Bill it was always about commitment. He used to say, you know talent is cheap, what really is required is the willingness to be dedicated to this and to stick with it, you know, to really invest yourself into the music. To make — this is not something you do lightheartedly. And this gets back to what you were asking me initially about my students and do I actually say to them the reality of what it's going to be like to be a jazz musician. Bill knew that only too well. I mean this is a man who could have done anything with music and in fact he mentioned this in an interview where in got to New York in '55 and some time between '55 and '56 he was approached by Tony Martin — do you remember that name, Tony Martin, the singer?

MR: Yep.

JL: Okay. Good. You're old enough, I can talk to you now, that's good. So Tony Martin, now we're talking 1955 dollars here, Tony Martin offered him $25,000 a year for a 17-week commitment annually. And Bill said it took him all of ten seconds to turn it down because he realized that if he took that job it was going to take him in another direction, it was going to distract him from being a jazz musician. Now having said that, he was perfectly willing to go out and play bar mitzvahs, weddings, you name it, like all of us, when you first hit the scene. Because that's part of the dues that you pay. But you take that in stride and it's not something that's going to just occupy so much of your time. Your focus is still completely on the music. So Bill was committed to playing jazz and being a jazz musician. And you can't stress that strongly enough to young people that want to be in jazz.

MR: At the same time you have to pay the rent so, you know, you can't really afford to have an attitude like I'm not going to play that club date.

JL: Oh no. You've got to take it all, man. I mean even when I was playing with Bill I was working with a wedding band on weekends when we were off in the Upstate area. Had to make some money.

MR: Did you save your calendars from those days?

JL: I've got a couple of itineraries, yeah.

MR: Yeah. Sometimes you open it up and you look back, it's like, oh I remember that gig, I remember that club and I remember that road — how tough — it's funny what we remember about gigs sometimes it's not the music, sometimes it's how many stairs do I have to go up.

JL: Well as you mentioned previously, my Woody Herman itinerary, I've still got a few of those, and they are packed. I mean it's day-in, day-out. I mean you had to do that in order to just pay for the band and pay for the bus. You had to work every day.

MR: Back to drum solos for a moment — do you prefer to play a drum solo over like a bass vamp or are you more comfortable if it's just the drummer?

JL: I don't mind a vamp, I mean for me, and this is what I've always taught to my students, it's all about the connection with the song form, whatever that song form is. I'm much more at home if I'm playing over a form, a standard tune or an original tune, I want something to work with. Because everyone else has something to work with. If you do that long enough then playing over an open vamp with a bass ostinato or not is easier. Because you can use your own imagination to create the arc you want to express. But I like playing over a form.

MR: About a year ago I interviewed a really fine bass player and he got on the thing about how come when it's time for the bass solo everybody stops? And I get nothing as far as

accompaniment. Do you have a decision to make when it's a bass solo, like should I help him out here? What should I do?

JL: Absolutely I do. You know that's another thing that I've always taught my drummers, the ability — to practice the ability to control your ideas at a low volume so that you can be an effective accompanist for a bass solo. Bassists don't want to hear [scats] on closed hi-hat. Forget it. You might as well not play. What they want is for you to engage with them rhythmically but unobtrusively. So as long as you keep that — the volume of the bass and the register of the bass primary in your sights, then you can start to gauge the kind of accompaniment that you can fill in underneath, the when and the how and the what, you know, to make it, to help that soloist, you know, play the best solo they can. And this is what you should be doing for every soloist in the band.

MR: In today's — well generally, who do you think is the main timekeeper in a combo?

JL: I've always felt that that was everybody's responsibility to play the time. The musicians that I grew up with, and that I grew up listening to, my brothers and I will say the same thing. We would go to Rochester and hear Joe Romano and Chuck Mangione and Don Menza. Those guys could stand on the stage and play without anybody and you feel that time, you know, rock solid. So that's what I expect from all musicians. They don't have to play it exactly the same feel that maybe I'm used to, but as long as they're playing with a consistent time that everyone can relate to, then we all have a starting point. We all have a place where we can start to communicate, and it can really get interesting.

MR: This may expose my musical tastes but it seems like I hear a lot of contemporary groups now where most people are playing with the time, instead of playing the time. And I wonder if you've noticed that kind of thing, maybe in a different fashion, but it almost feels like they're avoiding being too obvious.

JL: You might have a valid point there, Monk. I haven't really thought about that too much. I mean I know musicians, like a Joe Lovano for example. Joe plays with the time in a way that makes it very very very fun to play along with. He'll sit back on the time, you know, he's not trying to like put it in a metric grid. He's playing around with the time and you know if you need a comparison for this, the way Basie's band sits back on the beat, right? So Bud Shank played like that. I played a lot with Bud Shank. He would play back on the time and really like it was almost like he was suspended above a solid rhythmic feel. He didn't want you to go back there with him, he wanted you to play a pulse that he could work with you know, and ride over the top of that. But he was definitely working with you.

MR: Yeah. Right. Imagine trying to fall back with like Billie Holiday or something.

JL: You know believe it or not the person who threw people the most and was probably the most rhythmically hip was Anita O'Day. I've never heard anybody that could back-

phrase like that and be exactly on the money. I think I worked with her when she was in her late 80s and she could swing you right off the bandstand.

MR: Wow. What inspired your move to the west coast?

JL: It really had to do with family considerations back then, You know I was married at the time to someone whose family was living in Phoenix, Arizona, they were getting older and she wanted to be closer to her parents. So I agreed to move west. I wanted to be in Los Angeles, you know, and our marriage started to fall apart for other reasons at the time, so in an attempt to not be too far away from my daughter, who was five at the time, I decided I'll go to Los Angeles and see if I can make a go of it there. And that was probably the best decision I ever made.

MR: Can you describe for me, I'm totally fascinated by the life of a studio musician and starting from the phone call, where that comes from be it X studio at this time and how much you know about the music and what is the expectation of the producer and all that stuff. That's a long question.

JL: It's a long question and unfortunately you're asking the wrong guy, Monk, 'cause I'm not a studio musician. I never have been. I mean I made the mistake early on when we got to town — my wife and I'm, I'm remarried now and we've been together now for 26 years and we have a hard and fast rule of a vacation every year. And one year one of the big film composers in Los Angeles put out the call to me for a session, you know, and it goes through a service. So I'm talking to the person at the service, she's saying so and so wants you for two days double scale, blah-blah-blah. And I said, "Oh gee, tell them thanks so much but you know I'm not available, we're going on vacation." And she was stunned. I mean she was literally like — she said, "Do you realize who this is?" I said, "Yeah," but you know "we've got our tickets booked, we're going" you know. So that pretty much ended any aspects — but I never really had a desire to do that. I came out here to play the music, which might seem insane at the time, but I realized that for decades there have been great jazz musicians on the west coast. My brothers and I grew up listening to all of the cats out here: Art Pepper, Bud Shank, Bill Perkins, you know Teddy Edwards, you name it. So I knew there was a scene here it just wasn't maybe as viable as New York City, but it's grown a lot over the years.

MR: Did you play a role in finding your own gigs for the music?

JL: Yes. You basically have to pound on doors, you know, make your presence known, call club owners. If you start to work in these clubs, and you know people started to call me. I started to work in town with people that were more well known in town, so gradually your reputation grows and then you can start to hit up a club owner and say I want to bring my own band in, and if you're lucky it will happen, and I was lucky, again.

MR: Did you play your share of exposure gigs?

JL: I suppose so. I mean you've got to give it away sometimes just to be seen or heard, and as long as you don't overdo it, but when you're a local player, even in a city like New York or Los Angeles, you quickly become a local musician, and along with that visibility is the understanding that now you're going to work for what everybody else works for in town and that's something that we had to work at, making an adjustment. So what Gillian and I decided was that I was going to, for quite a while, stop working the local gigs and just focus on the touring. Because we realized I could go away for three weeks and come back with enough money to cover like a half a year's worth of in-town gigs.

MR: That's really interesting. So you have to go away from home to be able to stay home later I suppose.

JL: And also to be able to have some bargaining power for the cost of your services.

MR: Let's talk about Jazz Compass for a bit. There was an interesting statement I read that you got aggravated that your projects were falling on deaf ears with most of the record companies, so there's a quote here about the label, "to provide the serious listener with outstanding improvisational music without compromise." What would be the compromise if you were with any number of labels?

JL: Plenty. Trust me. You know when you sign on with a major label they want to have a lot of input into what you're going to put out. And that was one of the things that Bill was always concerned about. If he was going to sign with a label he had to have complete control over the content. But I don't even think it ever got to those discussion points. But you could actually be required to play songs you don't want to play necessarily, you know, maybe play things in a style that is more popular that you don't necessarily want to play. There are a number of ways in which you would have to compromise, to satisfy some producers.

MR: You just gave me a flashback. I was privileged to do a session with James Moody years ago and I happened to have his most recent CD with me, which was a tribute to Henry Mancini. So I told him how much I enjoyed it and he was like, "Yeah, but that's not what I wanted to do." James Moody.

JL: Yeah. I've heard tell that John Coltrane didn't necessarily want to make the ballads album, but I'm so glad that Bob Thiele was able to talk him into it because this is our favorite listening record around here.

MR: So as a composer I see a piano behind you. Where do your compositional ideas start?

JL: They come from anywhere, you know. I don't know how familiar you are with any of my records but "Native Land" for example, on that one I've got I think five originals, and this tune called "Sixth Sense" which is actually in 5/4 but the melody is a subdivision of 7 over 5. So that came to mind when I was practicing something at the drumset — I'm playing two with my bass drums, three with my hi-hat, and seven or five on the snare

drum. And I'm hearing all of this stuff just layering very nicely, and I thought you know there's a possibility for a tune in here. So I started to hear something. Then on my first record, "Message From Art" which is a dedication to Art Blakey, that came to me like bam as I was driving on the freeway. And I mean it came in fully composed and by the time I got home I was able to write it out. Yeah. Don't even ask — I don't know how. It's just the way it is you know.

MR: I can picture that, like don't talk to me for a minute, I've got to get this down or I'm going to lose it.

JL: Yeah, exactly. The tune "Kind of Bill" that's on that same album I worked on that for almost ten years. I mean it was a struggle, a struggle. But I finally got that thing.

MR: Working at it sitting at the piano?

JL: Yes. Oh absolutely, that was a total piano tune, had to be, Bill Evans.

MR: Wow, that's fascinating. What is the music business now for you, and what is your observation on what has happened to the music business in the last ten years?

JL: Oh man it's been in such a state of flux you know, with the advent of streaming and CDs are now not a viable way to go, realistically. You know it's really made it more difficult for a young person who wants to get started in jazz to get their foot in the door you know. The gigs of course are catch-as-catch-can but at least it used to be possible on a gig if you had a CD you could sell it. You know but these opportunities are disappearing. I feel fortunate that I'm at the kind of the back end of this thing because I stopped touring in 2018, I just said I'm not going on the road anymore. So what I'm doing now is just playing in town with musicians that I want to play with, my own band and some younger musicians that I would like to help get their name out there a little bit more. That's my focus. But that's a luxurious position to be in because, you know, I've already been there done that. I worry about my students that are starting out now but the fact is that I've always said this and I believe it sincerely, this music will always survive. Because it's just too strong of an art form, it's too strong of a concept, and there are just so many people, young and old, that want to be involved with it.

MR: Have you been overseas on tours playing jazz?

JL: Oh for years. I mean that's when I said going on tour, you know, in the last 26 years I was going to Japan, Europe, New Zealand, annually I was going all over the place.

MR: Was there a noticeable difference in the audience reaction in general?

JL: Oh I think in a city like New York or Los Angeles, you know it's possible to encounter an audience that might be a little more blasé, but I have never experienced that. The audiences here are great. People really want to hear the music, they want to be a part of the music. Overseas obviously if you're someone coming from out of the country to visit and as someone that they all know from a record or a video or something, that might add

a little more draw power or maybe a little more celebrity to what you're doing, but I find jazz audiences to be pretty universal.

MR: Let's pretend you're at a cocktail party and you get in a conversation with a person you don't know and they don't know who you are, so if they ask you what you do, what's the first thing you say?

JL: I say I'm a jazz drummer.

MR: And then they say, "Oh yes, jazz, well I like it until they start doing that stuff and then I don't — what the heck are they doing? How do they know when to stop and start." I mean do you try to answer or do you just go get another drink?

JL: It depends. I mean if the person strikes me as someone that is actually being sincere I'll spend some time and talk to them. In fact I really like hearing comments from people after gigs, they'll come up and they'll start out by saying, "I don't know anything about jazz" or "this is the first time I've ever heard jazz." But they'll give me their impressions. And I would say nine times out of ten, their impressions are pretty accurate. All we need from a listener, from an audience, is a willingness to participate. A willingness to sit there and actually do what we're doing, which is to tune in exclusively to the music. And just react to it. What are you feeling? I feel the same way when I go to a museum or an art gallery. I don't know much about art but I can certainly have a reaction to what I'm seeing and I can certainly get a feeling from the music. It really is all about feeling. You can get a feeling from a painting, you can get a feeling from music. If you're willing to go there and will let that happen then that's all I ask of you.

MR: I totally agree. I used to work with elementary school teachers, not music teachers. And they would make comments about music that I never would have thought of, they were so perceptive, and not with the music language. You know we usually speak in the music language and they had these other words and I said oh I have to take note of that. It's very informing.

JL: Yeah. Because at the end of the day it's really all about communications. You might think you're hip, you know, you might think you've got the greatest stuff on the planet to offer, but if you're not communicating with an audience then I think it's pointless. You need to get your music across to people.

MR: How do you teach that to students?

JL: It really starts basically with adherence to the song form. So if you're connecting everything you do, whether it's accompaniment or improvisation to a song form, right away you've made a connection to everything that's going on. Now hopefully the band as a collective unit can get that point across to the listener. That's — that's as succinctly as I can put it because you know beyond that it's really just doing it over and over again until you start to feel like you are getting a reaction from an audience for the appropriate

reason, you know, not because you played some blazingly fast single stroke rollover, or you were going crazy all over the drumset. The fact that you did something that communicated with the audience. And this gets back to those comments that I would get from lay people. People would say you know I could really hear you trying to help that soloist. That means more to me than anything else someone could say.

MR: Excellent. What's your feeling about, this is a large question, the state of our country at the moment?

JL: Oh God, Monk.

MR: I know.

JL: Well at the moment I tend to be very optimistic. But you and I both know that lying in the weeds is something very evil and something that if we're not mindful of is going to come right back and rear its ugly head and be right in our faces again. So to that end we're doing what we can do to support people that we feel are going to help take us in the right direction, keep us in the right direction.

MR: Is there anything in particular either musically or in life in general that makes you angry?

JL: Angry, well yes of course. You know injustice makes me incredibly angry, and to hear lies being said over and over again and believed by 70 million? How many people was it? I don't even want to — I really hate to go there but the number of people that are fooled by the lies that are being told, that makes me angry. To see blatant disregard for rule of law, that makes me very angry. To see money being siphoned to the top exclusively and then to have to go outside and drive around and see homelessness in numbers that you can't even imagine. It's staggering. That makes me angry. To realize that people are hungry, that makes me angry. We have so much wealth in this nation and the inequity of all of that, it gets me going.

MR: Okay. Thanks for answering that. Have you ever had to let someone go, a musician who made you angry about something?

JL: Made me angry about something.

MR: Well or just, you know I've asked this question a number of times and I should say that most people say I've never fired anybody, I just don't call them again.

JL: Oh well that's —

MR: Have you ever been in that position?

JL: Certainly there are people that maybe you prefer to work with, so that will be the person you call for a job. Now if it's someone that you've worked with over and over and over again, like say they've been in your band for years, and you decide to part ways then there has to be a really good reason. And really, the number one reason for that is simply if that person is becoming a problem if that person is disruptive. If that person is not contributing to the music because they're constantly undermining maybe your decision

about something or just harping on about whatever comes to mind. A person like that can be a cancer in a band. I've never experienced that, fortunately.

MR: Okay. Well here's an opportunity to talk about your upcoming book, for a moment.

JL: Great.

MR: What made you decide to do it, and what can we expect to learn about Bill Evans? You don't have to give away all your good stuff but —

JL: Oh that's okay, I don't mind sharing a couple of things. But the reason I wanted to do it was because these stories were fresh in my mind starting in, you know, 1980 after he passed. And I just kept re-experiencing them and mulling them over. So sometime in the '90s I started to write them down. And then they were just kind of compiling and I would have different episodes of things. And when I had enough material together I reached out to one of my former graduate students who was older, Charles Levin. And Charles for 25 years was a newspaper journalist so he had experience in the field of writing. And we started working on this together and it started to really take shape and so now we're at a point where it's really, I think it's going to be something worthwhile for people to read. There's a lot of anecdotes about Bill that I share from my personal experience with him because I actually spent time living with him in his apartment from time to time you know. And we were on the road a lot, and things that I had seen and also we were able to track down witnesses, you know people that were actually there when I describe an event for example. I'll give you an example. Here's one that I don't mind sharing because it's with a buddy of mine, Peter Erskine. So when I was on Woody's band, in 1972 we played the Newport Jazz Festival in New York. It was called Reunion at Newport. Alan Broadbent had written a feature tune with that title and it was featuring Stan Getz and Al Cohn and Zoot Sims and Chubby Jackson. I think was Red Norvo there, I can't remember. A number of people that were in Woody's bands over the years, right? So that was our segment. I went backstage and I see this skinny kid with long hair, he's 19 years old and we meet and it's Peter Erskine. And I say, "What are you doing?" He says, "I'm playing with Stan Kenton." I says, "Well how long you been with the band?" He said, "Tonight's my first night." So what happened with Peter was he had been hired to play with June Christy. Nobody knew who he was, not even the guys in Kenton's band, right? So Peter shows up, long hair, nobody knows him. He sight reads all of June's stuff perfectly. They do the gig, he does a fantastic job, and right after the gig Stan says, you know, "Have your bags packed tomorrow morning" you know, "meet us in front of this hotel." That was actually a fun recollection and I was able to get Peter to describe it from his perspective, and he did a great job.

MR: That's interesting, almost like a reporter who needs to get confirmation about their stories.

JL: Well that is one Charles's strengths because he's very good at investigative journalism. He's very good at tracking people down and he's very good at conducting the interviews and getting the correct information, for what we need.

MR: What's in the near future for you? John tells me that he's got a recording coming up I believe.

JL: Hopefully that's going to happen because I love playing John's music you know. John is an interesting study, Monk, because when we were kids he was always reading. And somewhere between "Popular Science," "Popular Mechanics" and Sherlock Holmes, this is where John's whole writing concept was formed and it's amazing. Plus a love for all the same music that we grew up listening to.

MR: There's a really enjoyable video of one of his pieces and the recording and I think you're in a room by yourself with headphones on. Does that take some getting used to?

JL: Oh sure it does. Especially with a big band. You know you're used to being in there and everybody feels everybody. You really want the band to feel what you're doing but it's just not practical anymore. Fortunately there's lots of, we have a great engineer out here and there's lots of great engineers, but the one we work with, Tally Sherwood, he has the ability of making it sound as if you're in the same room together. That's crucial.

MR: Well that's a talent, yeah.

JL: But you know to answer your question which is what's on the horizon, I'm actually getting ready, next weekend my quintet is doing a live album recording at a club called Sam First. Now Sam First is inaugurating with this project, their own record label. Sam First Records. So we're going to be their first project so I'm excited about that. I'm writing for that and Bill Cunliffe is writing for that, so the band is excited about getting together and just playing again. It's been so long. So that's on the horizon. That's coming right up.

MR: Okay we'll wrap up shortly. The guy at the cocktail party —

JL: Wait a minute, where's my drink if I've got to talk to that guy?

MR: He says, "What's the worst gig you ever played?"

JL: That's tough.

MR: It is tough.

JL: The worst gig I ever played. Oh it was probably some club date that you know was just so aggravating from start to finish. Nothing really comes to mind, Monk. I could tell you the most unusual gig that I ever played.

MR: Please do.

JL: When I was with Tony Bennett we were scheduled to appear at a Friar's Club Roast here in Los Angeles. And we were on with Doc Severinsen's Tonight Show band so Eddie Shaughnessy, you know and all the cats and us. Well around four o'clock that afternoon,

tragically, Ed Shaughnessy's younger son was killed in a car accident. So Ed of course was not going to be available. So they come looking for me at the last minute to go in and play with the Tonight Show band, which I was more than willing to do. But we couldn't find Tony Bennett's road manager. He had disappeared. And he had my cymbals and my stick bag. And Eddie, like any drummer would do, had his cymbals and his stick bag with him. So the only thing that was on the stage was Ed's drumset, which is massive, and hi-hat cymbals. So I ended up playing with the Tonight Show band for about thirty minutes, maybe forty minutes with two butter knives and I'm trying very carefully to not break the heads, with these two butter knives, playing along with the band while we do our little set. And then fortunately, by the time it was Tony's set we tracked down the road manager and we got my cymbals and my sticks. But here's — I'm playing behind Conte Candoli and Snooky Young you know and Pete Christlieb, but I've got two butter knives in my hands.

MR: I can just see, what happens when you're playing a ballad? No Joe, brushes, we want brushes.

JL: Good luck. I don't know what I did, honestly, Monk, it's a long time ago. But that's the oddest thing that's ever happened to me.

MR: All right, that qualifies as most unusual. Well I really enjoyed our conversation today and I hope for the best for your new recording and for John's, and I have to say that this is the first trio of brothers I've been able to meet with and it reminds me of Elvin, Hank and Thad. And boy, it's quite a legacy, that I don't know how much we can set all of this success on your father's lap, but he did a good thing.

JL: Both my parents did, both our parents did. And I have to say going through this music business with my brothers together as been the most fun. That's what's made it the most fun. We've been in this together from the beginning and still to this day. You know? That's the best part of it.

MR: Maybe I should get all three of you on a Zoom and just let you go at it telling stories.

JL: Oh you know we have a Zoom every Sunday morning and since you've done your interview with Pat and I've watched it and John's watched it, you know, Pat revealed things to you that he never revealed to us. So now we're starting to get the stories rolling you know, on those Zoom calls. And it's really — John had a lot of things to say last time that were very interesting. So I'm even, to this day I'm learning things about my own brothers that I didn't realize.

MR: Fantastic. Last question. If you had a convention of drummers sitting around having a few drinks who do they talk about as the drummer of most distinction?

JL: Wow. You know I'm going to take a stab here and say most distinction probably, and it's my generation, they're probably going to say Elvin Jones. Probably going to say Elvin. I

mean it could be Buddy Rich, who I admired greatly. It could be Tony Williams. But overall in terms of shaping the sound and the feel of the drums and setting the course for the next generation and beyond, Elvin Jones's impact is monumental. I would venture a guess that it would be Elvin.

MR: Wow. I saw him live once and he made an impact on me. I mean he was fierce when he was playing and yeah, talk about communication, it was there.

JL: You betcha.

MR: Yeah. Well thanks a lot for your time today.

JL: You're welcome, Monk. It's been a pleasure speaking with you. I knew it would be, but thanks for the invitation and hope we see each other face to face soon.

MR: Okay. See you on the flip side.